When we got to the ground, I carefully brought out my bats from Rohit's bag with their new livery and walked out to practise with them. They were looking superb and my team-mates all commented on them as they could see the thought that had gone into the design. There's no doubt they added to the occasion.

One way and another, it was a morning like no other. First the Mumbai Cricket Association congratulated me on notching up 200 Test matches and then the Government of India launched a special stamp to celebrate the achievement. I was told that I was only the second living person to be honoured with a stamp in that way, the first being Mother Teresa. What could I say to such a thing? Frankly, I was speechless.

Cricket at last

Most of the crowd wanted to see me bat, so a loud cheer went up when it was announced that India had won the toss. But they were quickly disappointed when MS Dhoni opted to field because the wicket was expected to offer some assistance to the fast bowlers in the morning. There was some bounce and even the spinners might come into play on the first day.

As we left the dressing room, the captain gave me the honour of leading the team out, which I did throughout the match. Gestures like that are memories I will always cherish. As we stepped onto the field the team also presented me with a special commemorative cap, and I spoke to them briefly during the team huddle. I reminded them of our duty towards the sport and the need to uphold the spirit of cricket at all times. I consider it the duty of every generation of cricketers to set examples for the next generation and inspire the youth to embrace the sport. It is the least we can do for the sport that has given us our identity.

As I looked around the stadium I was feeling really happy that, for the first time, my mother was there to watch me. In fact, my entire family, my wife and children, brothers, sister and her husband, uncle and aunt, were all in the stadium and I felt blessed by the affection and support the crowd was showering on me. There was nothing more a sportsman could have asked for. All that was needed to top it off was to perform well with the bat to leave my final mark on the sport I love so much.

We bowled brilliantly to get the West Indies out for 182 on the stroke of tea, at 2 p.m., with Pragyan Ojha taking five wickets and Ashwin